

See also: Vattel's *The Law of Nations* 108 ■ Scandinavian cooperation 160–161 ■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219 ■ INTERPOL 220–221 ■ The European Court of Justice 234–241

(USSR). Sweden remained neutral but vulnerable, as war raged all around it.

Postwar alignments

After the war ended, Sweden put forward to Norway and Denmark a plan for a Scandinavian defense union, but initial talks broke down. There were significant pressures in different directions from the major world blocs. European countries were forming the economic ties that would lead to the European Union. The US, eager to establish bases in Scandinavia, insisted that the Nordics were too weak to defend themselves and must join the emerging North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO). The USSR coveted Finland.

Disadvantaged by their war-ravaged economies, Denmark and Norway, along with Iceland, joined NATO as founding members in 1949. Sweden maintained its neutrality. And Finland, anxious for stable relations with its powerful land neighbor and erstwhile enemy, signed the Finno-Soviet Treaty—



which was an agreement of “friendship, cooperation, and mutual assistance”—in 1948.

The Nordic Council

Despite the failure of the defense union idea, in 1952 Danish prime minister Hans Hedtoft proposed a Nordic Council, intended simply as a consultative inter-parliamentary body rather than as a stronger union. Norway, Sweden, and Iceland quickly agreed, and the first session was held the following year in the Danish Parliament, with Hedtoft as president. Within a few years of its inception, the Council introduced

The Øresund Bridge, linking Sweden and Denmark, is almost 5 miles (7.85 km) long. It spans the sea between Malmö and the island of Peberholm, then continues by tunnel to Copenhagen.

practical dimensions to Nordic cooperation: a joint labor market and a passport union enabled citizens to travel freely and to work and reside anywhere in the region.

The Council proved remarkably resilient. After Stalin died, relations between Finland and the USSR softened, and in 1955, Finland joined the Council. Representatives from Greenland and from the Faroe and Åland Islands joined later.

In 1962, the five Nordic countries bonded even more closely with the signing of the Helsinki Treaty—a formal agreement of cooperation. Nine years later, this led to the creation of the Nordic Council of Ministers, which is responsible for intergovernmental cooperation. Its vision is for the Nordic region to become the most environmentally sustainable and integrated region in the world. ■



Legal harmonization

There has been a tradition of legislative cooperation in the Nordic region since 1872, when lawyers from all the nations convened in Copenhagen. Later, the desire for judicial harmonization formed a key part of the Helsinki Treaty, which sought “cooperation in the field of law with the aim of attaining the greatest possible uniformity in the field of private law.” One of the Treaty’s stated aims was to achieve uniform rules for penalizing criminal

offenses. Article 5 states that the aim should be to allow a crime committed in one Nordic nation to be prosecuted in another.

Although there has been cooperation between the countries, political differences have been an obstacle to complete harmonization. In recent years, EU harmonization has taken priority over Nordic aims. That has proved problematic, since Denmark, Finland, and Sweden are EU members, but Iceland and Norway are not.